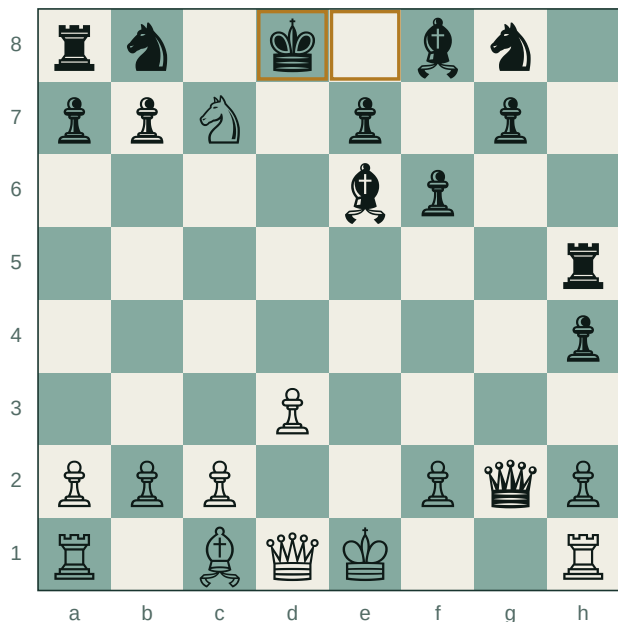


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 12

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 11...Kd8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

12. Nxe6+ Kc8 13. Qxh5

12.Nxe6+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. From e6 it attacks king on d8 and bishop on f8. Recorded reply: **12...Kc8**.

13.Qxh5 The queen captures the rook on h5.

At the end, nominal material is White 31 / Black 29 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +8. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +8: the balance goes from -6 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on d8. Geometrically undefended: bishop on f8 and rook on a8. Check for tactical protection.